

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

**Volume 7: Jewish Community and Identity in the Early Modern Period, 2010,
Wesleyan University, Middletown, CT**

Merchants and Rabbis - The Family of Josko of Lviv.

Jerzy Mazur, Towson University - Baltimore Hebrew Institute, USA

ABSTRACT: Josko of Lviv was one of the most important Jewish entrepreneurs in the late medieval Poland, specifically in the eastern provinces of Polish Kingdom, namely the voievodships of Russia and Lublin. Josko engaged in the number of profitable commercial activities, but achieved real prominence as the leaseholder of royal customs in such important urban centers as Lviv, Lublin, Chelm and Belz. His successful service to Kazimierz Jagiellon, John Olbracht and Alexander Jagiellon became the point of contention during the session of Polish Diet in Lublin in 1505. In this year Polish parliament demanded that Josko would be removed from his official position in the royal service. Shortly after this dramatic intervention of the Polish noblemen Josko died in Lublin, and left behind his wife Golda and children. One of his sons, Shachna, a pupil of Jacob Pollack, became the foremost rabbinical authority in Poland, and his yeshiva graduated such influential scholars as Solomon Luria and Moses Isserles. This presentation will examine the history of Josko and his family in the first three decades of 16th century. It will analyze the importance of Josko as the royal servant and how the fortune he left help his sons, especially Pyessak and Shachno to establish themselves as an important leader of the community in Lublin, and more broadly in eastern Poland. Number of important primary texts, issued mostly by the royal chancellery, will be utilized here, all pertaining to Josko and Shachno.

This presentation is for the following text(s):

- Court record from Lublin Castle (1533)
- The Letter (Privilege) with the Royal Seal Presented by Rabbi Schachno from the Lublin's Suburb

Copyright © 2012 Early Modern Workshop

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

**Volume 7: Jewish Community and Identity in the Early Modern Period, 2010,
Wesleyan University, Middletown, CT**

Court record from Lublin Castle (1533) **Court record from Lublin Castle** **1533**

Translated by Jerzy Mazur, Towson University - Baltimore Hebrew Institute, USA

Castriensia Lubliniensia, 4, 89v, 1533

Prudent (*providus*) Martinus Szythko, architect/builder from Lublin, is standing before this office and its records, and abandoning all his other jurisdictions, is submitting his case to the castle (*grodzki*) court, and testifies publicly, that he made a contract for constructing the house on a hill, for the sum of 20 *marcas* and 2 *grossis* with Prudent (*providus*) Schachno, the doctor of the Jews from the district located near the Lublin castle (*subcastrum*).

First of all, he will build a day-room, from this room a chamber, from this chamber a room alias *Vychod*, and from this room another room until the end of the pool. From the last room, there will be a passage to the kitchen, and these will be *forstowanis*. And in the same place, near these rooms, the entrance halls, or *przysyonki* will be built, and furthermore the antrance, another day room, with a kitchen belonging to this room, and from this kitchen *vychod*. And all of these will be lined from outside and inside with wooden boards. And all these entrance halls and rooms will be provided with wooden stilts. And on the top of these entrance halls and rooms will be built a bond, or *vyazanie*, so it will be closed and create atrium. And in this atrium will be built six rooms, or fortowane, with steps, benches, windows, and moreover there should be bought the stilts and curtains for the pool, rooms, entrance halls and kitchens; and from this part also silverware (?), or *slyophatky* (*slyopharki*) for the entire house. (And with this) aforementioned architect Sythko obliged himself under the punishment of incarceration and tower, to conduct no other work for other people, other than on this house. And he obliged himself during this court case, to build this until the holiday of St. Jacob Apostle. And he provided the guarantee of another 22 *marcas*.

Copyright © 2012 Early Modern Workshop

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

**Volume 7: Jewish Community and Identity in the Early Modern Period, 2010,
Wesleyan University, Middletown, CT**

Court record from Lublin Castle **Court record from Lublin Castle (1533)** **1533**

Prepared by Jerzy Mazur, Towson University - Baltimore Hebrew Institute, USA

Castriensia Lubliniensia, 4, 89v, 1533.

Constitutus personaliter coram officio et actorem punitibus providus Martinus Szythko architector de Lublyn, recedendo a suis juribus quibusuis et huix Juris castriensie se in toto incorporandum publice et per expressum recognovit quia contractum fecit cum provido Schachno doctore Judeorum de subcastro Lublynense ad construendam domum in aggere pro viginti marcis et duabus grossis. Qui inprimis debet construere stubam, de eadem stuba comnatam, de eadem comnata camera et de Camera alias Vychod, aliasque cameram de fine a piscina, de qua camera erit transitus ad coquinam et iste erunt forstowanis. Ibideque penes easdem cameras palacia alias przysyonki construens agent, necnon palacium, aliam stubam ac eciam cognatam ad eandem stuba pertinent, et de eadem coquinam vichod. Quas ista omniam construere debet podhybel desuper et intus et camere debent esse constructe alias zrobyone. Quas stubas et cameras omnes et nsuper inniam edificia interra ponere daret asseribus alias thanzyczamy, Et super edifficys eorundem stubarum et camerarum daret construere ligamnam alias vyazanye prout in in se contineri deberet et facere atrium. Et in eondem atrio sex cameras alias fortowane et omnes gradus, scamna, fenestralia in prefata domum construere daret necnon palos y sthandary ab illa parte piscinis sub eiusdem cemeris palacys et coquinis debet intromittore alias nabycz, et ex ista parte plates slyophatky emittere daret pro tota domum. [Cum?] prefatus Sythko architector inscripsit et submissit sub carceribus et turri non alium laborem exreceris alicum hominum tantum istum hinc domum pertinens, quam daret seu se submissit eandem statuere et prout forum debet pro festo sancti Jacobi Apostoli nunc instancia sub vadio aliarum viginti et duarum marcarum pecunie.

Archive: Castriensia Lubliniensia, 4, p. 89 v

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

**Volume 7: Jewish Community and Identity in the Early Modern Period, 2010,
Wesleyan University, Middletown, CT**

The Letter (Privilege) with the Royal Seal Presented by Rabbi Schachno from the Lublin's Suburb

**Littere infrascripte sub sigillo Sacre Regie ex parte perfidus Schachno
doctorem Judeorum de subcastro Lublynense
Feria sexta in Crastino Lamberti, Anno 1534 (1533)**

Translated by Jerzy Mazur, Towson University - Baltimore Hebrew Institute, USA

Lwow and Belz Duty Chambers

Aleksander etc. we hereby declare that our Jew Josko was allowed to lease the duty chambers in Lwow and Belz between the holiday of the Purification of Mary 1506 and another holiday of the Purification of Mary 1508. For the reason of this lease, he was absolved and exempt from all the yearly payments, which he usually delivered to us for himself, his house and family, according to the custom of all our Jews. Similarly, we freed this Josko, his family and servitors from [the iurisdiction] of all our *wojewodas*, castellans, burgraves, judges, deputy judges and other our dignitaries and officials of any stature, for the entire period of these three years. However, because of the admonitions and demands of our lay and ecclesiastical councilors, and of the and emissaries of the Crown provinces congregated here, we removed aforementioned Josko from this lease; for this reason he is absolved. Hence, his desired indemnity is secured; we give aforementioned Josko, his family, servants and factors the freedom and exemption from things and goods he customarily delivered to us, also from all annual taxes he paid for himself, his house and properties, and from the jurisdiction of *wojewodas*, castellans, *starostas*, burgraves, judges, deputy judges and other our dignitaries and lay officials of any stature. We free and exempt them on the holiday of Purification of Mary in the aforementioned year one thousand five hundred and eight; we also decided, that during the period of the lease, neither Josko and his family should pay annual taxes and duties to the chambers in Lwow and Belz, nor should they be responsible to aforementioned courts, but only to us and these, who will be dispatched with our special letters of authorization. Therefore, we order you, who are or will be interested (have competence) in this, so that aforementioned Josko in these our freedoms (exemptions) preserve and guard during this time, and do not act against it (under the threat of losing our favours).

Announced (Datum) during the parliamentary session (*conventionone generali*) in Lublin, Saturday before the *Oculi* Sunday (Third Sunday in Lent), in the year of Our Lord 1506.

Copyright © 2012 Early Modern Workshop

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

**Volume 7: Jewish Community and Identity in the Early Modern Period, 2010,
Wesleyan University, Middletown, CT**

Littere infrascripte sub sigillo Sacre Regie ex parte perfidus Schachno doctorem Judeorum de subcastro Lublynense

**The Letter (Privilege) with the Royal Seal Presented by Rabbi Schachno
from the Lublin's Suburb**

Feria sexta in Crastino Lamberti, Anno 1534 (1533)

Prepared by Jerzy Mazur, Towson University - Baltimore Hebrew Institute, USA

Metryka Koronna, XXI, p. 381 (this is corrected version of a document published in: F. Papee (Ed.), *Acta Alexandri Regis Poloniae, Magni Ducis Lithuaniae etc.* (1501-1506), Kraków: Polska Akademia Umiejętności, 1927, p. 527-8).

Leopol. et Belz. thelonea.

Alexander etc. Significamus etc., quod licet Leopoliense et Belzense thelonea nostra a festo Purificationis Mariae anni Domini 1505 ad aliud festum eiusdem Purificationis Mariae anni Domini 1508 judeo nostro Josko arendaveramus. ratione cuius arendae ipsum ab omnibus solutionibus annalibus, quas nobis ratione personae, domus et familiae suae more aliorum judeorum nostrorum impendere consuevit. ac eundem Joskonem familiam suam et servitores ipsius de omnibus et singulis omnium et singulorum palatinorum, castellanorum, burgrabiorum, iudicum, subiudicum ceterorumque dignitariorum et officialium nostrorum cuiuscumque status et conditionis existentium secularium .per omne tempus istud trium annorum eximeramus et absolveramus, tamen quia ad ammonitionem et adhortationem consiliariorum nostrorum spiritualium et secularium nobis [cum] in praesentiarum congregatorum et nuntiorum terrestrium arendam ipsam ab eodem Joskone alienavimus: iccirco indempnitati ipsius providere cupientes, Joskonem praefatum ab omni Leopoliensis et Belzensis theloneorum in solutione. quam a rebus et mercibus suis nobis impendere consueverunt. ab omni quoque solutione annua, quam more aliorum judeorum ratione personae, domus et bonorum suorum nobis debet, ac a iudiciis omnium palatinorum, castellanorum, capitaneorum, burgrabiorum, iudicum, subiudicum ceterorumque dignitariorum et officialium secularium cuiuscumque status et conditionis existentium eundem Joskonem et familiam servitoresque et tactores suos liberandum et eximendum

duximus, liberaviinusque et eximimus praesentibus ad festum praefatum Purificationis Mariae anni praedicti millesimi quingentesimi octavi; decernentes, quod ipse Josko nulla thelonea (s) Leopoliense et Belzense ac nullas solutiones annuas dabit aut solvet, nec coram iudicibus praefatis ipse aut farnilia sua respondebit, nisi coram nobis aut illo vel illis, cui vel quibus litteris specialibus nostris ipsuin iudicandum commiseramus, durante arenda praefata. Quapropter vobis mandamus quorum interest aut intererit in futurum, quatinus Joskonem praefatum in praesenti libertate nostra conservetis et conservare curetis ad tempus praefatum, aliter non facturi pro gratia nostra. Harum etc. Datum in conventionione generali I,ublinensi, sabbato ante Dominicam “Oculi.” Anno Domini 1506.

Archive: Castriensia Lubliniensia, 4, p. 124 r,v

Copyright © 2012 Early Modern Workshop

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

**Volume 7: Jewish Community and Identity in the Early Modern Period, 2010,
Wesleyan University, Middletown, CT**

Littere infrascripte sub sigillo Sacre Regie ex parte perfidus Schachno doctorem Judeorum de subcastro Lublynense

**The Letter (Privilege) with the Royal Seal Presented by Rabbi Schachno
from the Lublin's Suburb**

Feria sexta in Crastino Lamberti, Anno 1534 (1533)

Prepared by Jerzy Mazur, Towson University - Baltimore Hebrew Institute, USA

Metryka Koronna, XXI, p. 381 (this is corrected version of a document published in: F. Papee (Ed.), *Acta Alexandri Regis Poloniae, Magni Ducis Lithuaniae etc.* (1501-1506), Kraków: Polska Akademia Umiejętności, 1927, p. 527-8).

Leopol. et Belz. thelonea.

Alexander etc. Significamus etc., quod licet Leopoliense et Belzense thelonea nostra a festo Purificationis Mariae anni Domini 1505 ad aliud festum eiusdem Purificationis Mariae anni Domini 1508 judeo nostro Josko arendaveramus. ratione cuius arendae ipsum ab omnibus solutionibus annalibus, quas nobis ratione personae, domus et familiae suae more aliorum judeorum nostrorum impendere consuevit. ac eundem Joskonem familiam suam et servitores ipsius de omnibus et singulis omnium et singulorum palatinorum, castellanorum, burgrabiorum, iudicum, subiudicum ceterorumque dignitariorum et officialium nostrorum cuiuscumque status et conditionis existentium secularium .per omne tempus istud trium annorum eximeramus et absolveramus, tamen quia ad ammonitionem et adhortationem consiliariorum nostrorum spiritualium et secularium nobis [cum] in praesentiarum congregatorum et nuntiorum terrestrium arendam ipsam ab eodem Joskone alienavimus: iccirco indempnitati ipsius providere cupientes, Joskonem praefatum ab omni Leopoliensis et Belzensis theloneorum solutione. quam a rebus et mercibus suis nobis impendere consueverunt. ab omni quoque solutione annua, quam more aliorum judeorum ratione personae, domus et bonorum suorum nobis debet, ac a iudiciis omnium palatinorum, castellanorum, capitaneorum, burgrabiorum, iudicum, subiudicum ceterorumque dignitariorum et officialium secularium cuiuscumque status et conditionis existentium eundem Joskonem et familiam servitoresque et tactores suos liberandum et eximendum

duximus, liberaviinusque et eximimus praesentibus ad festum praefatum Purificationis Mariae anni praedicti millesimi quingentesimi octavi; decernentes, quod ipse Josko nulla thelonea (s) Leopoliense et Belzense ac nullas solutiones annuas dabit aut solvet, nec coram iudicibus praefatis ipse aut farnilia sua respondebit, nisi coram nobis aut illo vel illis, cui vel quibus litteris specialibus nostris ipsuin iudicandum commiseramus, durante arenda praefata. Quapropter vobis mandamus quorum interest aut intererit in futurum, quatinus Joskonem praefatum in praesenti libertate nostra conservetis et conservare curetis ad tempus praefatum, aliter non facturi pro gratia nostra. Harum etc. Datum in conventionione generali I,ublinensi, sabbato ante Dominicam “Oculi.” Anno Domini 1506.

Archive: Castriensia Lubliniensia, 4, p. 124 r,v

Copyright © 2012 Early Modern Workshop